



Seeds on the Move



Plants are different to animals in many ways. One very big difference between plants and animals is that plants cannot move on their own. They do not have legs to get up and move from where their roots are planted. So, how do they grow all over the place?

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Plants make seeds that grow into new plants. If seeds can only drop to the ground, under their parent plant, they might not get enough sun, water or nutrients from the soil.

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Plants have developed special sets of adaptations for their seeds. This means that seeds can move away from their parent. This process is called seed dispersal.

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Some seeds can float or fly by wind dispersal. Here, the shape of the seed is important to make the best use of the wind. Seeds from dandelions and cattails are light and feathery. Some seeds have wings. Elm and maple trees have helicopter-like seeds that flutter and fly in the wind in order to move.

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Next, there are the sticky seeds. These seeds have “sticky” adaptations that help them to stick to animal fur or feathers, or to clothes. Have you ever walked through a field and found seeds stuck to your socks and shoes? Can you shake the seeds off? Seeds that hitch a ride like this are very clever.

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Some seeds become food and move by animal dispersal. When these seeds are eaten by an animal, they pass through the animal’s digestive tract and grow after they have been excreted. Birds are key in seed dispersal. They like to eat fleshy fruit with seeds on trees and fly away, then disperse the seeds in their droppings.

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Some plants like to grow near water, and use flowing water to transport their seeds. Seed dispersal is a great example of adaptation. The seed adaptations help plants make the most of their habitat. This is how plants can grow in so many different places.

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